

(a) Does Google's page-ranking algorithm systematically exclude pages holding opinions that only a small segment holds?

No, not by explicit design, but that doesn't mean the effect can't be systematic. Google's ranking is built to surface pages judged most relevant and authoritative using signals such as links (PageRank), content quality, and user behaviour; those signals tend to favour widely linked, popular, and frequently clicked pages, which tend to reflect majority or well-resourced viewpoints. Personalization and other filters (such as location and past clicks) can further reduce the visibility of minority viewpoints. Because the system optimizes (SEO) for what most users find useful (a consequentialist goal), minority opinions often show up lower in results, even if they are valid. This means that small-segment opinions get less exposure. That outcome is ethically troubling from a utilitarian lens when it lowers overall social welfare (ex, by reducing civic debate), even if the algorithm's intended aim is utility (relevance and user satisfaction). ([Massachusetts Institute of Technology][1])

(b) Should every opinion on the Web be given equal consideration?

No, treating all opinions equally in algorithms isn't supported by utilitarian ethics. Utilitarianism encourages us to choose policies that boost overall well-being. Giving the same visibility to harmful, misleading, or risky misinformation, even if only a small group believes it, can cause serious social problems, like poor public decisions, health risks, or unfair influence in elections. On the other hand, prioritizing trustworthy, evidence-based information usually benefits everyone. Studies show that how content is ranked can strongly shape what people believe and how they act, so platforms have a responsibility to minimize harm. From a utilitarian viewpoint, algorithms should promote accurate information and reduce harmful effects, while still allowing space for genuine minority opinions through features that support discovery and transparency. This way, we protect the overall good, an informed and diverse public conversation.

References

For (a):

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For (b):

Epstein, R., & Robertson, R. E. (2015). The search engine manipulation effect (SEME) and its possible impact on the outcomes of elections. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 112(33). <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.1419828112>

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